Despite the recognition that American assistance to India would create problems with Pakistan, Deputy National Security Adviser Carl Kaysen advised Kennedy that the administration "must push through."[260] The State Department told McConaughy that the US would not be forced by the expected Pakistani "temper tantrums" into giving balancing aid to Pakistan or pressuring India. Responding to implied Pakistani threats that it might withdraw from the Southeast Asia Treaty Organization and the Central Treaty Organization, State told the ambassador to remind Pakistani leaders that all American military aid to Pakistan was linked to those alliances. On Pakistani suggestions that American aid to India would lead to closer Sino-Pakistan relations, he was to make clear that the US would view "seriously" such "flirtations" or an "entente." The US would not understand or tolerate an ally giving "aid and comfort to Chinese" while they were attacking the subcontinent.[261] McConaughy subsequently cautioned the Pakistani foreign minister against any "accommodation" with China.[262]

As the war went on, US assistance to India increased significantly. There was public support in the US for aid to India. Of the people who had heard or read about the fighting between China and India, roughly two-thirds thought that the US should help India (14 percent said no).[263]

The initial request from India was only the tip of the iceberg. When fighting resumed after a lull in mid-November and the Indian military situation became desperate, Nehru made further requests in two letters to Kennedy on November 19. The first made clear that India would need "air transport and jet fighters." Later that same evening, Nehru wrote to the president asking for "more comprehensive assistance." He requested American-manned fighter squadrons and radar equipment to defend Indian cities, as well as bombers that would be flown by Indians trained in crash courses in the US. Furthermore, he requested the US Air Force to "assist the Indian Air Force in air battles with the Chinese air force" over Indian territory in certain instances. He voluntarily attached a "string," assuring Kennedy that India would only use US-supplied equipment against China.[264] Galbraith interpreted this as a request "amounting to joint air defense."[265] This was a significant step—just five years earlier, India had been sensitive about even agreeing to allow the US Navy to store anything in India or the Indian Navy to refit US ships in its facilities.[266]